

SG/Send for Accountants: Secure Client Communication for SME Practices

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audience Accounting firms and sole practitioners serving small and medium businesses

from Ambassador

The Problem Every Accountant Knows

You handle the most sensitive information your clients have. Tax returns, bank statements, payroll records, passport copies, Companies House filings, VAT returns, personal identification, contracts, director loan accounts, profit and loss statements — it's all confidential, and it all needs to move between you and your clients regularly.

Right now, most of this happens through:

Email — the default. Your client emails you a photo of their passport, their P60, their bank statements. You email back their draft tax return for review. All of it travels across the internet in cleartext, sits in both inboxes indefinitely, gets forwarded, gets backed up to cloud services neither of you control. If either email account is compromised, everything is exposed.

WhatsApp — the quick option. A client sends you a photo of a receipt, a screenshot of their bank balance, their UTR number. WhatsApp is end-to-end encrypted between users, which is good. But chat histories are backed up to iCloud or Google Drive, and by default those cloud backups are NOT protected by WhatsApp's end-to-end encryption. So your client's passport photo may be sitting in a plaintext cloud backup they don't even know about.

Post — still used for original documents, signed forms, and anything that needs a wet signature. Slow, expensive, and things get lost.

Client portals — some practices use them, but they're expensive, clients find them confusing (another login to remember), and adoption is often poor. Half your clients end up emailing you anyway because the portal is too much friction.

USB drives and in-person handoffs — secure, but impractical for remote clients and modern hybrid working.

The problem isn't that you don't care about security — you do, and your professional obligations (GDPR, ICAEW/ACCA codes of conduct, anti-money laundering regulations) require it. The problem is that the secure options are expensive and high-friction, so everyone defaults to the insecure but convenient ones.

What SG/Send Does

SG/Send is a zero-knowledge encrypted file and message transfer service. It works in the browser — no software to install, no accounts to create, no portal for your client to remember.

The core principle: **your client doesn't need to install anything**. They just need a web browser and a decryption key that you give them separately (by text message, phone call, or in person). This is the key

difference from tools like Signal or Proton — where both parties need the same app. With SG/Send, only you need to know about it. Your client just clicks a link and enters a key.

How It Works

- 1. You open SG/Send in your browser
- 2. You upload a file or type a message
- 3. The content is **encrypted in your browser** before it leaves your device
- 4. You get a link and a separate decryption key
- 5. You send the link to your client via email, and the decryption key via text message (or vice versa)
- 6. Your client opens the link, enters the key, and decrypts the content in their browser

The server never sees your data in plaintext. Not the file, not the message, not the key. Even SG/Send cannot read what you've sent. This is what "zero-knowledge" means — the server knows nothing about your content.

Why Two Separate Pieces?

Security depends on two secrets sent via two different channels:

Secret	What It Is	Send It Via
The link	Locates the encrypted file on the server	Email, Slack, client portal, text message
The decryption key	Unlocks the content	A DIFFERENT channel — text, phone call, WhatsApp, in person

An attacker who intercepts the email gets only the link — which points to encrypted bytes they can't read. An attacker who intercepts the text gets only the key — which has nothing to decrypt. Both must be compromised simultaneously.

Five Use Cases for Your Practice

1. Sharing Tax Returns and Financial Documents

The scenario: you've prepared a client's self-assessment tax return, corporation tax return, or annual accounts. You need to send it to them for review and approval before filing.

Today: you email the PDF. It contains their full name, address, UTR number, NI number, income details, dividend records, property income, capital gains — everything HMRC knows about them, sitting in an email inbox. If the client forwards it to their spouse or business partner, it's now in multiple inboxes.

With SG/Send: upload the tax return PDF to SG/Send. Send the link via email ("Your draft tax return is ready for review"). Send the decryption key via text message. The client opens the link, enters the key, and downloads the PDF in their browser. The document never exists in plaintext on any server. When they've downloaded it, the link can be set to expire.

What this protects: UTR numbers, National Insurance numbers, full income details, property addresses, capital gains records, dividend income, bank interest — all the information that makes identity theft trivially easy.

2. Receiving Client Identification Documents (KYC/AML)

The scenario: you're onboarding a new client. Anti-money laundering regulations require you to verify their identity. You need a copy of their passport or driving licence, plus a proof of address (utility bill, bank statement).

Today: the client emails you a photo of their passport and a scan of their bank statement. Their passport number, date of birth, photo, and full banking details are now in your email, in their sent folder, on both email servers, and in any cloud backups. If you're audited on your AML compliance, you need to show you store this securely — email doesn't qualify.

With SG/Send: you send the client a pre-prepared message via SG/Send explaining what documents you need. They use SG/Send to send you the passport photo and bank statement — encrypted, with a key they give you over the phone. You decrypt, verify, and store securely in your practice management system. The SG/Send link expires. No passport photos sitting in email inboxes.

What this protects: passport numbers, dates of birth, photos, signatures, bank account numbers, sort codes, home addresses — the core identity documents that AML regulations require you to protect.

3. Exchanging Banking and Payment Information

The scenario: you need to set up a client on your system for a refund, or a client needs to give you their bank details for a BACS payment, or you need to share your firm's bank details for invoice payment. Or the client needs to share login credentials for their accounting software (Xero, QuickBooks, FreeAgent).

Today: bank details are exchanged by email. Sort codes, account numbers, sometimes even online banking credentials. This is the primary vector for invoice fraud — an attacker intercepts an email with bank details and substitutes their own. Payment redirection fraud costs UK businesses millions every year.

With SG/Send: the client sends their bank details via SG/Send. You receive the link, they tell you the key on the phone. You see the details, enter them into your system, and the link expires. The bank details never sit in an email thread. For software credentials: the client sends login details via SG/Send with a one-time download — you use them once, and the link is gone.

What this protects: bank account numbers, sort codes, online banking credentials, accounting software logins, payment references — everything an attacker needs for payment redirection fraud.

4. Sending Confidential Advice and Sensitive Messages

The scenario: you need to send a client sensitive advice — a tax planning recommendation, a note about a potential HMRC enquiry, guidance on a director's loan issue, a warning about a cash flow problem, or a confidential personnel matter in their business.

Today: you send an email. If the client's email is a shared inbox (common in small businesses), other staff may read it. If their email is managed by an IT provider, that provider has access. If they're using a free email service (Gmail, Outlook.com), the content is scanned for advertising purposes.

With SG/Send: type the message in SG/Send. It's encrypted in your browser, sent as a link, decrypted only by the person with the key. No one else can read it — not their office staff, not their IT provider, not their email service, not you (after you've sent it). If the message is time-sensitive, set it to expire after 24 hours.

What this protects: privileged advice, tax planning strategies, information about HMRC enquiries, sensitive business information, personnel matters, cash flow warnings — anything you'd mark "private and confidential" on a letter.

5. Sharing Contracts, Engagement Letters, and Legal Documents

The scenario: you need to send an engagement letter for signature, or share a draft contract that your client's solicitor needs to review, or circulate a shareholders' agreement, or send Companies House forms for director approval.

Today: email, often with password-protected PDFs (where the password is sent in the same email thread, defeating the purpose). Or post, which adds days to the process.

With SG/Send: upload the document, send the link by email, send the key by text. The client downloads it, reviews it, and when the signed version needs to come back, they use SG/Send to send it to you. The document has never existed in plaintext on any email server. Both parties have a record of the exchange (the encrypted link and the decryption key) without the content being exposed.

What this protects: contractual terms, financial commitments, director details, shareholder structures, company formation documents — information that competitors, disgruntled employees, or malicious actors could exploit.

What Your Client Sees

This is what matters — if your client can't use it, nothing else matters.

1. They receive an email from you: "Your draft tax return is ready. Click here to download it securely."
2. They click the link. A clean, simple page loads in their browser.
3. They enter the decryption key (which you sent them by text message).
4. The document appears. They download it. Done.

No account creation. No app installation. No portal login. No password to remember. Just a link and a key. If your client can open a website and read a text message, they can use SG/Send.

What's Coming Next

These features are in development or available through a professional services engagement:

Feature	What It Does	Why It Matters for Accountants
Expiring links	Files automatically become inaccessible after a set time (1 hour, 24 hours, 7 days)	Tax returns don't sit on a server forever. Passport copies expire after you've verified them. Time-boxed access.
One-time download	File can only be downloaded once, then the link is dead	Send credentials or banking details that can only be retrieved once. You know exactly one person downloaded it.
Read receipts	See when your client opened and downloaded the file	Know whether your client has actually looked at their draft tax return before the filing deadline.
Custom encryption keys	The client defines their own key, reused across all transfers	Regular clients don't need a new key every time. Set up a shared key once, use it for the whole tax year.
PKI / certificate support	Encrypt with a public key; only the private key holder can decrypt	Your firm publishes a public key. Clients encrypt documents with it. Only your firm can read them. No key exchange needed.
Co-branding	Your firm's logo, colours, and domain on the SG/Send interface	Clients see "Secure Document Exchange by [Your Firm Name]" — professional, branded, trustworthy.
Client authentication	Require login before accessing files — integrated with existing identity providers	Only verified, named individuals can access sensitive documents. Full audit trail.
Data rooms	A dedicated encrypted storage area per client, with folders and structure	All documents for a client engagement in one place — encrypted, organised, accessible to authorised users only.
Document signing	Sign documents directly within SG/Send, or integrate with third-party signing services (DocuSign, Adobe Sign, etc.)	Engagement letters, tax return approvals, board minutes, contracts — signed and returned through the same encrypted channel. No printing, scanning, or posting. Research in progress on both native signing and integration approaches.
Markdown rendering	Text messages displayed with formatting (headings, bold, lists)	Send structured advice notes that read like a proper document, not raw text.

Deployment Options

Option	Description	Best For
Shared instance	Use the main SG/Send deployment at send.sgraph.ai	Trying it out. Small practices with occasional use.
Dedicated instance	Your own SG/Send deployment with your subdomain (e.g., secure.yourfirm.co.uk)	Practices that want branding and client-facing professionalism.

Option	Description	Best For
Self-hosted	SG/Send deployed in your own AWS account	Firms with strict data residency requirements or existing AWS infrastructure.

All options use the same zero-knowledge encryption. The only difference is who owns the infrastructure.

Regulatory Alignment

Requirement	How SG/Send Helps
GDPR (data protection)	Personal data is encrypted at rest and in transit. The server never sees plaintext. Data can be set to auto-expire. You can demonstrate "appropriate technical measures" for protecting personal data.
AML / KYC (anti-money laundering)	Identity documents are transferred encrypted, not via email. You have a record of when documents were sent and received. Passport photos don't sit in email inboxes.
ICAEW / ACCA codes of conduct (client confidentiality)	Client communications are encrypted end-to-end. Confidential advice doesn't pass through third-party servers in readable form.
Professional indemnity	Demonstrable security measures reduce your risk profile. If a client's data is breached via email, your insurer will ask why you used email. SG/Send is a defensible answer.
HMRC data security	For agents filing on behalf of clients: sensitive tax data (UTR, NI numbers, income) is never transmitted in cleartext.

SG/Send doesn't replace your practice management system or your document retention policy. It replaces the insecure channel you use to move sensitive documents between you and your clients.

Cost

SG/Send is serverless. For a typical accounting practice:

- **Shared instance:** free to try, minimal cost at scale (pennies per transfer)
- **Dedicated instance:** infrastructure cost under £50/month for most practices. The real cost is our setup time, not the AWS bill.
- **Self-hosted:** your AWS costs, which for document transfer volumes typical of an accounting practice, will be negligible

Compare this to: a client portal subscription (£50–£200/month), a secure email add-on (£5–£15/user/month), or the cost of a data breach (ICO fines start at the "standard maximum" of £8.7M under UK GDPR, though SME penalties are typically lower — the reputational damage is the real cost).

Getting Started

1. **Try it now** at send.sgraph.ai — send yourself a test file, see how it works
2. **Send your first real document** — next time a client emails you a passport photo, reply with: "Thanks — in future, could you send sensitive documents through our secure channel? Here's how: [link]"
3. **If it fits**, we set up a branded instance for your firm — your domain, your logo, your clients seeing your name on a professional, secure interface

The product works today, in your browser, right now. Your clients don't need to install anything. That's the point.